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WITH SADIA ZAHOOR & ALI HASSAN SARGANA

DAILY CURRENT AFFAIRS

TUESDAY, 20 OCTOBER 2026 | 19 OCT COVERAGE: 00:00 TO 23:59 PKT

LEAD STORY / PAKISTAN & CENTRAL ASIA

Dar Advances Tajik Ties as SCO Leaders Gather

Meetings in Dushanbe centred on trade, connectivity, energy and regional cooperation.

In Dushanbe, Pakistan placed trade routes, energy links and regional diplomacy on the same agenda. On 19 October, Ishaq Dar met Tajik Prime Minister Qohir Rasulzoda and joined delegations gathering for the SCO heads-of-government meeting. The two sides examined cooperation in trade, investment, energy, connectivity and water security, according to Radio Pakistan.

The diplomatic test lies in turning regional meetings into workable transport arrangements and durable economic ties. Pakistan's Central Asian ambitions remain closely connected to the wider political and security environment.

SOURCES Radio Pakistan: meeting / SCO session

TODAY AT A GLANCE

POLIO RETURNS TO KARACHI

The NEOC announced a new case in District East, taking Pakistan's 2026 tally to seven.

SECURITY LOSSES IN BALOCHISTAN

ISPR reported four militants killed and Major Wajahat Waheed martyred.

PUMP PRICES REDUCED

Petrol fell to Rs381.14 per litre and high-speed diesel to Rs389.27.

CHINA REPORTS FASTER GDP GROWTH

Third-quarter output rose 4.5 percent year on year, according to Beijing's statistics bureau.

FRANCE REQUESTS PARTIAL CURFEWS

The prime minister sought limited measures after a weekend of violent unrest.

01 PAKISTAN

DIPLOMACY / LEAD

Dar Advances Tajik Ties as SCO Leaders Gather

Meetings in Dushanbe centred on trade, connectivity, energy and regional cooperation.

Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar met Tajik Prime Minister Qohir Rasulzoda in Dushanbe on Monday, 19 October. Radio Pakistan reported that both governments agreed to deepen cooperation in trade, investment, energy, defence and connectivity. The meeting also covered culture, people-to-people exchanges, climate change and water security. Dar highlighted possible cooperation through Pakistan's National Disaster Management Authority. He arrived in Tajikistan to lead Pakistan's delegation at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Council of Heads of Government, scheduled for 19–20 October. The council addresses practical economic and budgetary cooperation among SCO members, distinct from the forum's heads-of-state summit.

ANALYSIS

Pakistan's access to Central Asian markets depends not only on agreements but also on reliable transport and energy links. Direct consultations with Tajikistan connect that economic objective with broader regional diplomacy.

CSS ANGLE Pakistan Affairs — Pakistan–Central Asia relations; regional connectivity and the SCO.

SOURCES Radio Pakistan / Radio Pakistan / Radio Pakistan

BACKGROUND

The SCO Council of Heads of Government is a forum for trade, finance, connectivity and socio-economic coordination among members.

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PUBLIC HEALTH

Karachi Polio Case Takes National Tally to Seven

A six-month-old boy tested positive for wild poliovirus in the city's East district.

The National Emergency Operations Centre confirmed a new wild-poliovirus case in Karachi on Monday. The child was a six-month-old boy from Union Council Jamali Colony in District East, and confirmation came from the Regional Reference Laboratory at the National Institutes of Health in Islamabad, according to Dawn. Pakistan's 2026 total rose to seven cases. Geo News, citing the same centre, reported five cases in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and two in Sindh. The centre said an anti-

BACKGROUND

Wild poliovirus remains endemic in Pakistan and Afghanistan; repeated vaccination and surveillance are central to elimination efforts.

ANALYSIS

A case in a densely populated transport hub increases the importance of detecting transmission early. Eradication requires vaccination coverage, rapid case investigation

polio campaign planned for 2–8 November would target more than 23.9 million children in 97 districts. Karachi had not reported a case since December 2024, according to Geo News.

and public cooperation.

CSS ANGLE General Science & Ability — communicable disease, vaccination and public-health surveillance.

SOURCES Dawn / Geo News

BACKGROUND

The October 18 operations were first publicly detailed in ISPR's 19 October announcement. Balochistan has faced sustained security threats.

INTERNAL SECURITY

ISPR Reports Major's Death in Balochistan Operations

Military officials reported four militants killed and an officer martyred.

On 19 October, Inter-Services Public Relations said security forces had conducted operations in the Jattakabad area of Kalat and in Shadi Kaur, Pasni, in Gwadar district. ISPR reported that four militants were killed and arms were recovered in the Jattakabad intelligence-based operation undertaken on 18 October. In clearance operations near Pasni, Major Wajahat Waheed, 34, was killed in an improvised explosive device attack, the military said. President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif issued condolence statements on Monday. The military said further clearance operations would continue. Allegations about external sponsorship were the Pakistani authorities' stated position, not an independently established finding.

ANALYSIS

Counterterrorism operations create continuing demands for intelligence quality, force protection and civilian security. Border management and provincial governance also affect the wider security response.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs — internal security, counterterrorism and civil-military coordination.

SOURCES Dawn / Geo News

ECONOMY / ENERGY

Government Cuts Petrol and Diesel Prices

The Petroleum Division notified lower rates for implementation on 20 October.

Pakistan's government notified revised petroleum rates on Monday, 19 October. Petrol fell by Rs5.16 per litre to Rs381.14, while high-speed diesel fell by Rs7.69 to Rs389.27, according to the Petroleum Division notification reported by Dawn and The News. The revised rates were to take effect on 20 October. The News said the government had introduced a framework for more frequent publication of fuel prices by the Oil and Gas Regulatory Authority. The rate reductions were announced amid considerable volatility in international energy markets. Changes in retail fuel costs can influence transport expenses and expectations for broader consumer prices.

BACKGROUND

Petrol and high-speed diesel have different uses: the latter is heavily used in freight and commercial transport.

ANALYSIS

Lower fuel prices can ease near-term operating costs, but the size and persistence of the benefit depend on future price revisions, taxation and the international oil market.

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CSS ANGLE Economics / Current Affairs — imported inflation, energy pricing and fiscal transmission.

SOURCES Dawn / The News

PARLIAMENT / LAW

Senate Passes Blue-Passport Bill for Former Lawmakers

The proposed entitlement covers those who served only part of a parliamentary term.

The Senate passed a bill on Monday to let former National Assembly and Senate members retain official blue passports even when they had not completed a full term. Senator Abdul Qadir moved the proposal, which would insert Section 3-A into the Passports Act, 1974, according to Dawn. In the same sitting, a separate proposal to extend the facility to dependent children of former lawmakers was withdrawn following government opposition. The bill approved by the Senate still requires National Assembly passage before it can become law. The discussion concerned privileges attached to public office rather than a change in the general passport system.

BACKGROUND

Under existing passport rules, official passports are issued to specified office holders and qualifying former officials.

ANALYSIS

The debate tests where law should draw the line between institutional entitlement and personal privilege. The legislative path also illustrates bicameral scrutiny.

CSS ANGLE Pakistan Affairs — Parliament, legislative procedure, privileges and administrative reform.

SOURCES Dawn / Pakistan Today

DEFENCE / FOREIGN POLICY

Saudi Envoy and Munir Discuss Makkah Defence Pact

Both sides cited progress in security cooperation during a Rawalpindi meeting.

Saudi Arabia's newly appointed ambassador to Pakistan, Dr Rajeh Tami Albugamy, met Chief of Defence Forces and Chief of Army Staff Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir in Rawalpindi on 19 October. Radio Pakistan, relaying the military statement, said the meeting covered regional security and matters of mutual interest. The two officials expressed satisfaction with progress under the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement and called for stronger defence collaboration, institutional ties and strategic coordination. The ambassador had recently assumed his responsibilities in Islamabad. The statement described the defence relationship in terms of bilateral cooperation and the wider framework of the pact.

ANALYSIS

Defence cooperation can support deterrence while also increasing the need for precise commitments and diplomatic coordination. Pakistan's security relationships intersect with wider Gulf tensions.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs — Gulf security, collective defence and Pakistan–Saudi relations.

SOURCES Radio Pakistan / Dawn

BACKGROUND

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye have developed a trilateral Makkah defence framework; earlier implementation decisions preceded the October 19 meeting.

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02 WORLD

CHINA / MACROECONOMY

China Reports 4.5% Growth in Third Quarter

Industrial production grew faster than consumer spending in September.

China's National Bureau of Statistics released its third-quarter economic figures on Monday. Gross domestic product rose 4.5 percent from a year earlier, compared with 4.3 percent in the second quarter. Growth over the first nine months was 4.6 percent. Reuters reported September industrial output growth of 5.5 percent and retail-sales growth of 1.1 percent, while fixed-asset investment over January–September contracted 7.2 percent. The official results showed resilience in production alongside weaker domestic demand. The NBS presentation stressed industrial development and employment stability; outside economists cited the property downturn and limited household spending as continuing constraints.

ANALYSIS

An export- and manufacturing-led recovery can support regional trade yet leave growth exposed to external demand. Pakistan's China-linked trade and investment prospects depend partly on this wider cycle.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs / Economics — China's economy, domestic demand and regional spillovers.

SOURCES China NBS / Reuters

BACKGROUND

GDP is a broad measure of the goods and services produced within an economy during a period.

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FRANCE / GOVERNANCE

France Seeks Local Curfews After Weekend Riots

Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu ruled out a citywide Paris curfew.

French Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu asked local authorities on 19 October to impose targeted evening curfews after a weekend of violent demonstrations. Reuters reported that the prime minister regarded limited local restrictions as more appropriate than a nationwide emergency at that stage; he excluded a blanket curfew across Paris. The unrest followed protests concerning living costs and public services. French government officials faced questions from city leaders over preparations for disorder. In financial markets on Monday, Reuters reported a fall in French

BACKGROUND

A partial curfew restricts movement in particular areas or time windows rather than across an entire country.

ANALYSIS

Public order measures raise proportionality questions, particularly when protests also reflect economic grievances. Market responses show how political uncertainty can raise sovereign borrowing costs.

equities and upward pressure on sovereign bond yields amid broader fiscal concerns. The government's curfew request was a policy response made on Monday; the major riots themselves took place earlier.

CSS ANGLE Current Affairs — European politics, public order and sovereign-debt risk.

SOURCES Reuters / Reuters

IRAN / RUSSIA / SECURITY

Iran and Russia Urge Diplomacy on Hormuz Security

Foreign ministers held talks in Tehran as maritime tensions continued.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi spoke at a joint news conference with Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov in Tehran on Monday. Reuters reported that Araqchi blamed the United States for insecurity around the Strait of Hormuz and called for diplomatic resolution of regional disputes. He advocated a security arrangement developed by regional states rather than reliance on foreign military forces. These assertions were Iran's stated position. Russia's foreign minister was visiting Iran amid continuing strains in Gulf shipping and energy security. The meeting demonstrated the diplomatic dimension of the crisis but did not establish that the parties had agreed on a negotiated maritime settlement.

ANALYSIS

Any interruption of this sea lane affects energy importers and trade costs well beyond the Gulf. A proposed regional security mechanism would require political agreement among states with competing threat perceptions.

CSS ANGLE International Relations — regional security architecture, maritime chokepoints and energy geopolitics.

SOURCES Reuters

BACKGROUND

The Strait of Hormuz connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and is a major international energy-shipping passage.

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BACKGROUND

The armed conflict between Sudan's military and the Rapid Support Forces began in April 2023.

SUDAN / HUMANITARIAN LAW

Drone Strikes Kill Children in Sudan's Capital

Rights monitors also reported severe civilian casualties in western Sudan.

A drone incident in Khartoum killed three children on Monday, 19 October, according to the Sudanese rights group Emergency Lawyers, as reported by the Associated Press. The group blamed the Rapid Support Forces; AP recorded no immediate response from the force. The same organisation accused Sudan's army of separate weekend drone strikes in West Kordofan, while Al Jazeera reported claims of more than 160 deaths in attacks across western regions since Friday. These figures were attributed to medics and rights groups rather than independently confirmed counts. The United Nations condemned attacks that were killing civilians and disrupting essential services. Both principal sides in Sudan's conflict faced allegations concerning attacks on civilian sites.

ANALYSIS

The use of remotely piloted weapons does not remove obligations to distinguish civilians from military targets. Allegations of attacks on markets and residential areas call for impartial investigation.

CSS ANGLE International Relations — armed conflict, civilian protection and international humanitarian law.

SOURCES Al Jazeera / AP

KENYA / JUSTICE

Kenyan Court Convicts 29 Over Shakahola Deaths

A judge found Paul Mackenzie and 28 others guilty in the deaths of 191 people.

A Kenyan court on 19 October convicted Paul Mackenzie and 28 associates over the deaths of 190 children and one adult linked to a starvation movement. Reuters reported that Mackenzie denied forcing his followers to starve; the court rejected that defence. The mass-grave investigation in Shakahola Forest had begun in 2023. Citizen Digital reported that Justice Diana Kavedza found an organised regime of isolation, coercion and fatal fasting. The verdict addressed 191 murder counts; the defendants were due to be sentenced on 6 November, according to Reuters. Defence counsel indicated an intention to appeal, while separate proceedings concerning other deaths remained unresolved.

BACKGROUND

Authorities recovered hundreds of bodies in Shakahola Forest after relatives and police raised concerns in 2023.

ANALYSIS

The judgment places accountability for child protection and coercion alongside freedom of religion. It also raises questions about early warnings, state oversight and access to education and healthcare.

CSS ANGLE International Relations / Sociology — human rights, state duty of care and accountability.

SOURCES Reuters / Citizen Digital

03 GENERAL KNOWLEDGE

01 DIPLOMACY Dar met Tajik Prime Minister Qohir Rasulzoda in Dushanbe on 19 October.

02 ORGANISATIONS The SCO heads-of-government meeting was scheduled for 19–20 October 2026.

03 DIPLOMACY Tajikistan talks covered trade, energy, defence and connectivity.

04 PUBLIC HEALTH Pakistan confirmed its seventh wild-poliovirus case of 2026 on 19 October.

05 PUBLIC HEALTH The infected Karachi child came from UC Jamali Colony in District East.

06 PUBLIC HEALTH NEOC reported five 2026 polio cases in KP and two in Sindh.

07 SECURITY ISPR reported four militants killed in the Jattakabad operation.

08 SECURITY Major Wajahat Waheed was 34, according to ISPR.

09 ENERGY The notified petrol price was Rs381.14 per litre from 20 October.

10 ENERGY The notified high-speed diesel price was Rs389.27 per litre.

11 PARLIAMENT The Senate approved a bill proposing Section 3-A of the Passports Act, 1974.

12 DEFENCE Saudi Ambassador Dr Rajeh Tami Albugamy met Field Marshal Asim Munir in Rawalpindi.

13 ECONOMY China reported 4.5% year-on-year GDP growth in Q3 2026.

14 ECONOMY China reported 4.6% GDP growth over the first nine months of 2026.

15 FRANCE Lecornu sought local and partial curfews rather than a blanket Paris curfew.

16 IRAN Araqchi held a joint news conference with Sergei Lavrov in Tehran.

17 SUDAN Emergency Lawyers attributed a Khartoum strike killing three children to the RSF.

18 KENYA A Kenyan court convicted Mackenzie and 28 others in a 191-death case.

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04 FIVE TERMS

01 Council of Heads of Government

An SCO organ focusing on economic, commercial and budgetary cooperation.

WHY IT MATTERS Dar participated in its Dushanbe meeting, where Pakistan pursued connectivity and trade.

Read source

02 Wild poliovirus

A naturally circulating poliovirus, distinct from vaccine-derived poliovirus.

WHY IT MATTERS The Karachi case was identified by the Pakistani surveillance network as wild poliovirus.

Read source

03 Intelligence-based operation

A security action planned around specific intelligence concerning suspected targets or hideouts.

WHY IT MATTERS ISPR described the Jattakabad operation using this terminology.

Read source

04 Year-on-year growth

The percentage change in a measured quantity compared with the corresponding period a year earlier.

WHY IT MATTERS China reported year-on-year third-quarter GDP growth of 4.5 percent.

Read source

05 International humanitarian law

Rules of armed conflict that seek to limit suffering, including protection of civilians.

WHY IT MATTERS Civilian-casualty allegations in Sudan involve duties to distinguish military targets from civilians.

Read source

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05 PRACTICE

MULTIPLE-CHOICE QUESTIONS / 15 ITEMS

01 Which country hosted the 19–20 October SCO heads-of-government meeting?

A. Kazakhstan B. Tajikistan
C. Uzbekistan D. Kyrgyzstan

02 Which official met Ishaq Dar during the 19 October bilateral talks?

A. Qohir Rasulzoda B. Daler Juma
C. Sergei Lavrov D. Rajeh Tami Albugamy

03 Pakistan's newly confirmed October polio case was detected in which Karachi district?

A. South B. Central
C. East D. West

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04 What was Pakistan's 2026 polio case tally after the Karachi confirmation?

A. Five B. Six
C. Eight D. Seven

05 Which district was associated with ISPR's Jattakabad operation?

A. Gwadar B. Kalat
C. Kech D. Awaran

06 How much did Pakistan reduce petrol's notified price per litre?

A. Rs5.16 B. Rs7.69
C. Rs3.93 D. Rs1.20

07 The newly notified high-speed diesel price was:

A. Rs381.14 B. Rs396.96
C. Rs389.27 D. Rs390.23

08 The Senate's blue-passport proposal involved amending which law?

A. Constitution B. Citizenship Act, 1951
C. Elections Act, 2017 D. Passports Act, 1974

09 Which Saudi ambassador met Field Marshal Munir on 19 October?

A. Dr Rajeh Tami Albugamy B. Daler Juma
C. Qohir Rasulzoda D. Abbas Araqchi

10 China's third-quarter 2026 year-on-year GDP growth was:

A. 4.3% B. 4.5%
C. 5.5% D. 4.6%

11 Which Chinese indicator rose 1.1% year on year in September?

A. Property investment B. Fixed-asset investment
C. Retail sales D. Gross capital formation

12 Which French leader requested partial local curfews on 19 October?

A. Emmanuel Macron B. Laurent Nunez
C. Marine Le Pen D. Sébastien Lecornu

13 Iran's foreign minister held a joint press conference with:

A. Sergei Lavrov B. Wang Yi
C. Marco Rubio D. Hakan Fidan

14 Which Sudanese group did rights monitors blame for the 19 October Khartoum drone strike?

A. Sudanese Armed Forces B. Rapid Support Forces
C. UNMISS D. ECOWAS

15 How many defendants were convicted in Kenya's Shakahola murder case on 19 October?

A. 28 B. 30
C. 29 D. 31

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ANSWER KEY

01 B — Radio Pakistan identified Dushanbe, Tajikistan, as the venue. Source

02 A — Tajik Prime Minister Qohir Rasulzoda held talks with Dar. Source

03 C — NEOC placed the case in District East, UC Jamali Colony. Source

04 D — The new case increased the confirmed national tally to seven. Source

05 B — ISPR situated Jattakabad in Kalat district. Source

06 A — The 19 October notification reduced petrol by Rs5.16 per litre. Source

07 C — The Petroleum Division's 20 October rate was Rs389.27 per litre. Source

08 D — The approved proposal inserts Section 3-A in the Passports Act, 1974. Source

09 A — Radio Pakistan named the new Saudi envoy as Dr Rajeh Tami Albugamy. Source

10 B — The NBS recorded 4.5 percent growth in the third quarter. Source

11 C — Reuters reported September retail-sales growth of 1.1 percent. Source

12 D — Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu requested targeted curfews. Source

13 A — Reuters recorded Araqchi's Tehran briefing with Sergei Lavrov. Source

14 B — Emergency Lawyers attributed the strike to the Rapid Support Forces. Source

15 C — Reuters reported the conviction of Paul Mackenzie and 28 others. Source

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10 Dawn, 19 Oct, Senate blue-passport bill

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